two Bretton Woods institutions, except every third year when the annual meetings are held in another country capital which is determined on the basis of some geographical balancing formula. The finance minister is India's nominee on the board of governors of both the IMF and the World Bank; the governor of the Reserve Bank is the alternative governor on the IMF board while the finance secretary is the alternative governor on the World Bank board.

Over the years, the Fund–Bank meetings have evolved into a nucleus for a host of other multilateral and bilateral meetings, regional briefings, conferences and seminars, some organized by the IMF and the World Bank, either jointly or separately, and some organized by think tanks and global financial institutions focused on the global economy, international development and world financial markets. This ever-expanding activity brings to Washington during the meetings week about 15,000 participants comprising finance ministers and central bank governors, and their staffers, chief executives of banks and financial institutions, investors and investment advisers, economists, corporates and consultants, and many well-known and also not-so-well-known experts, all milling around the Fund–Bank complex of office blocks and the numerous cafeterias around in the Foggy Bottom area of downtown Washington DC, just a couple of blocks from the White House. And, of course, the media from all around the world is present in full force—with their mikes, cameras and lights—beaming images, filing stories and reports, and eagerly chasing any minister or senior official in sight for a sound bite.

The IMF has a membership of 188 countries, organized into twenty-four constituencies, with each constituency represented by an executive director. Just as owners of a company hold shares in it, countries hold 'quotas' in the IMF, with each country's quota based largely on its relative position in the global economy. Quota subscriptions are a central part of the IMF's financial resources. A member country's quota determines its maximum financial contribution to the IMF, its voting power and its access to IMF financing. The five largest quota holders—the US, Japan, Germany, the UK and France—as also China and Russia are single-member constituencies